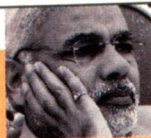


he asks the mesmerised crowd.

Narendra Damodardas Modi has a lot to prove—about himself. Tonight in Ankleshwar, in Bharuch district in south Gujarat, it seems nothing more is left to be proved about the issue on which this election is being fought. It is Modi and more of him. He is the agenda, the manifesto, the force that sways, divides and dominates. He is not fighting an election in a conventional sense, for on the other side of the political divide, there is no face, no name to demolish. Rather than fighting against a phantom opponent, he is fighting for himself. It is a referendum on one of the most captivating transformative sagas in Indian politics. Or call it the trial of the season: a show trial of democracy in which multiple variations of Modi are seeking justice. The moderniser is pitted against the manufactured monster. The master divider is in combat with the manipulator of mass mind. Once upon a time, he was just another chief minister, a lucky *swayamsevak* who found himself in the highest seat in Gandhinagar. Then, one day in Godhra, men and metal burned together on the rail tracks. The Sabarmati Express on flames was an act of terror, and it happened in the



MODIBITES

“Sohrabuddin was killed in Gujarat. The Sultanate of Delhi can hang me for that.”

“Sonia is throwing mud at me. I don’t know whether it is from Italy or India. And lotus blooms in mud.”

“You vote for lotus and I’ll give you Lakshmi.”

“Their biggest allegation is that I have 250 kurtas. They added a zero to the figure.”

“Words come to me naturally. I enjoy talking. It’s God’s gift.”

“I have not taken a one hour vacation in five years.”

“I’ll prove elections can be won on development.”

dreadful afterglow of 9/11, but the anguish it evoked outside Gujarat was strangely subdued. The post-Godhra riot, which in the beginning was not a clash between two communities but the murderous rage of the majority, presented a suitable bogeyman to liberal India.

The horror of Gujarat 2002 has been abridged to the size of one man. He lost the drawing rooms beyond Gujarat, and the international headlines, in the absence of fresh masters of ethnic or religious cleansing, got a brand new bad boy on the right. That could have been the end of Modi had he not realised the uses of adversity. As Modi, the freshly minted monster, prompted the outraged conscience keepers to seek out such easy—and lazy—catchwords like Auschwitz and Final Solution, he himself was busy setting the stage for Modi Part II, a meticulously-planned project in self-modification. Election 2002 was a referendum on terror, and his object of derision was the other M word—Mian Musharraf. Development was not in his glossary then; he fought in the name of national honour. That was a time when, elsewhere in the world, evil stepped out of the Bible and became part of the political narrative. He campaigned as an aggrieved Hindu nationalist—and won.

The Modi who looms over Gujarat 2007 is larger, stronger and overpowering. The conqueror’s gait can’t be missed as he alights from a Toyota Prado and walks toward the elevated stage. His 56” chest, which is reportedly a campaign asset in the projection of masculine Hindutva, gets further puffed up as he surveys the crowd—the most awestruck Modiites among them stand out in their Modi masks. He always begins on a low tone, teasing and cajoling. The prologue is intimate; then the volume goes up, the joke gets darker, the daring gets intimidating, and the shrillness resonates across the barricaded stadium. Modi at his verbal best aspires to be an interactive—and incendiary—Cicero without the Roman’s refinement or mind. Spellbinding, yes, but occasionally flip-pant and personal, but never indecent. (“I’m dignified in my attack, haven’t you noticed?” he tells you after one



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